CHAPTER NINETEEN

Amnesia and Antisemitism in the "Second Jagiellonian Age"

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The year 2014 marks the 25th anniversary of the emergence of free Poland from the corroded shackles of Communist rule. According to nearly every socioeconomic parameter, during the course of the past quarter century the country has made extraordinary progress. Today, firmly embedded in NATO and the European Union, 40-million strong Poland can and should be seen as the greatest success story in post-Communist Europe. This development has not gone unnoticed in the wider world. Harking back to its golden age, when Poland was one of the great powers in Europe, the *Economist* went so far as to characterize the present time as the "Second Jagiellonian Age."[1] Indeed, in some respects, Poles have never had it so good, at least not in modern times.

This dramatic national rebirth has also been accompanied by a remarkable revival of Jewish life, which is all the more striking when seen against the backdrop of the contemporary history of Poland and the pathology of anti-semitism that has long bedeviled Polish society. To be sure, Poland has traditionally been associated, and not by Jews alone, with rabid antisemitism and the Holocaust. In some quarters, Poles have even been seen as people who absorbed implacable antipathy toward Jews "with their mother's milk."[2]

That notion gained ground in the years leading up to the German invasion of Poland and during the occupation itself.[3] The fact that murderous anti-Jewish violence was widespread even after the end of the war during which some 85% of Polish Jewry was wiped out reinforced that perception.[4] In recent times, it was further compounded by the 1968 exodus of citizens of Polish Jewish origin (many of whom did not identify themselves as Jews) compelled to leave in the face of anti-Jewish repression.

Since the collapse of Communism, Poland has clearly become a much more hospitable place for Jews and even—in myriad fields—a hothouse of Jewish creativity, most of it the work of non-Jews. Indeed, some Poles have enthusiastically embraced their country's Jewish past through events such as

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